

**NATIONAL STRATEGY
FOR CONTINUING VOCATIONAL
TRAINING DURING
THE PERIOD 2005-2010**

INTRODUCTION

The strategic goal of the European Union until 2010 is the creation of the most competitive in the world, dynamic, based on knowledge economy, with more and better work places and higher social cohesion. The achievement of this goal requires exceptional attention to be paid to provide appropriate education and vocational training for improving the suitability of the labour force for employment. The public administration of Republic of Bulgaria, a country for which accession to the European Community is imminent, takes into consideration the European strategies, policies and practices in the field of the continuing vocational training. We consider as leading in this respect the Lisbon Strategy till 2010, the life-long learning concept, the “Education & Training 2010” Programme, the European Employment Strategy and others.

During the period of transition to a market economy and the accompanying intensive process of restructuring the production, it's obvious a definite trend of discrepancy between the quality of the labour force and the new requirements. It is more strongly expressed in comparison with the future requirements of the national labour force, having in mind the pre-accession processes and the developing globalization. There is a important task for the reform in education, and particularly in the vocational education and training in Bulgaria – to provide such conditions for vocational training, which will allow continuously keeping of the quality of the labour force and its suitability for employment in compliance with the requirements of the labour market and the knowledge-based economy. This task can be fulfilled by continuous vocational training for everyone on equal access and equal conditions. It is necessary a clear, concrete, target-defined in the time and social space strategy, secured by resources, which will develop the continuing vocational training in the country. The Strategy is mutually bound with similar documents for the social and economic development: the Governmental Programme, the National Plan for Economic Development until 2006, the National Plan for Development until 2013 - in preparation now, the Employment Strategy for 2004-2010 and others.

The **Purpose** of the Strategy is to help the development of the reform in the vocational education and training by creation of conceptual, methodological and planning conditions for its implementation.

Subject of the Strategy is the training of persons aged above 16 for earning, developing and perfecting vocational qualification in order to improve the suitability for employment, to assist the professional career and individual development.

The **Goal** of the Strategy is to outline the national priorities for development of the continuing vocational education in the context of the life-long learning as well as to point out the institutions responsible for the implementation.

I. PRESENT SITUATION, TRENDS AND CHALLENGES IN THE FIELD OF CONTINUING VOCATIONAL TRAINING

1. Present Situation and Trends in the Labour Market

The labour market is characterized by quantitative and qualitative disbalance during the transition period. The demand of jobs considerably exceeds the supply of such. In the same time, the qualitative characteristics of the unemployed labour force do not correspond to the qualitative structure of the offered work places. The negative demographic situation deepens the discrepancies and the unwilling effects in demanding and supplying of work places. The negative growth in population and the considerable outside migration have an adverse effect on the absolute number and the structure of the labour resources in Bulgaria. A permanent trend for decreasing of the active population is observed.

Predominant part of the total labour force are people graduated secondary schools – 55,7%; ones graduated high schools are 23,4%, and those with lower stages of education are 20,9%.

As a result of the economic stabilization during the past years, the unemployment goes down. The unemployment level in the country for 2003 was 13,7%¹. High levels of the long-term unemployment and low educational and skill levels of the unemployed are still typical. Over 40 % of the long-term unemployed in 2003 were without any skills or had the lowest skill level. For the remaining part, as well as for many of the employed, a serious problem is de-qualification – this applies especially for the older-age groups. Considerable is the level of the youths' unemployment (28,1%). For many of the youths the reasons are the low level of education, the lack of a profession or lack of practical experience.

The qualitative structure of the labour force in the regions is different.

The distribution of the unemployment in the regions and towns is uneven; the same applies for the qualitative structure of the unemployed.

The demand for labour force² changes depending on the general condition of the economy, the seasonal factors and the development of the subsidized employment. The decision of the employer for realization of labour with certain quantitative and qualitative characteristics has a decisive significance.

Those specific factors, together with the European and world trends for continuous growth of the requirements for employment suitability, determine the need of continuing vocational training both for all-aged groups of labor force and considering also the territorial aspect.

The training for acquisition of vocational qualification by the people included in the labour market is organized by the Employment Agency. The total number of the carried out training courses in 2003 is 1977, which exceeds more than twice the number of the same in 2000.

The main part of graduated some vocational training in 2003 (29 294 persons) were unemployed at the time they were included in. The number of employed people who graduated such training during the same period is 8 863 persons. In a comparison with 2000, the number of people that have graduated training for acquisition of vocational skills was totally 12 569 and the employed people were only 496³.

If we share the different kind of trainings, it prevails the acquisition of additional vocational skills - 67,4%, next comes the training for re-qualification – 22,9% and the training for obtaining initial vocational skills – 9,7%. There is a trend for increasing the number of training courses for additional vocational skills - in fact they were 2/3 of all carried out in 2003.

2. Legal Frame

In the **Constitution of Republic of Bulgaria** (1991) are laid down the basic principles for free development of the education (art. 23) and everyone's right for education (art. 53), which were

¹ Data of the National Statistical Institute.

² Data of the administrative statistics of the Employment Agency.

³ Data of the administrative statistics of the Employment Agency.

further developed in a series of laws and regulations. The basic laws, which regulate the legal frame of the continuing vocational training in the country, are:

The **Labour Code** – LC (1986, last amended in 2004): establishes the rights and obligations of those who are engaged in and during the training for acquisition and raising the qualification and re-qualification on the basis of agreement between the employer and employee;

The **Public Education Act** – PEA (1991): provides the main normative organization of the education; regulates the right of the citizens to continue raising their education and qualification; determines the role and place of the State Educational Requirements as well as the order for issuance of documents for obtaining educational degree and skills;

The **Vocational Education and Training Act** – VETA (1999): provides the normative organization of the initial and continuing vocational training with a main goal to guarantee the quality of the vocational education and training in conformity with the needs of the labour market and in compliance with the trends in the European Union; determines the functions of the system of vocational education and training (VET) to prepare people for realization in the economy and society, providing conditions for acquisition and permanent raising of the vocational skills;

The **Higher Education Act** – HEA (1995): regulates the organization, functions, administration and financing of the higher education in Republic of Bulgaria; provides conditions for synchronization of the Bulgarian system of higher education with the European trends for access to a quality preparation, the possibilities for mobility within the system and the transparency of the acquired qualifications;

The **Employment Promotion Act** – EPA (2001): formulates the transition from passive social assistance towards active measures of the labour market in order to increase the employment and raise the qualification of the labour force; introduces stimuli for employers to train employed for updating and raising their qualification and to train unemployed, in the context of life-long learning; regulates the types of continuing vocational training organized by the Employment Agency and the conditions for its accomplishment;

The **Crafts Act** – CA (2001): regulates the conditions and rules for training crafts, including training by master at a concrete work place in the craft enterprise; determines the basic degrees of the craftsmen training;

The **People's Community Centers Act** – PCCA (1996): regulates the activity of the community centers within the country for fulfillment of their main tasks, including expansion of the people's knowledge, united people with the values and achievements of the science, art and culture through training and creation of possibilities for studying;

The **Convention on Technical and Vocational Education** (signed in Paris on 10.11.1989, deposited by UNESCO, effective from 29.08.1991; in Bulgaria effective from 01.10.1994, the bill passed by Decision of the Council of Ministers № 236/15.06.1994) – our country confirms its readiness to develop policies and strategies for technical and vocational education within the frame of the educational system that will provide conditions for acquisition of knowledge and skills by both youths and adults, which are needed for their economic and social development, as well as for the individual and cultural growth of the personality in the society.

3. Institutions Responsible for the Continuing Vocational Training

On the national level:

The **Council of Ministers** (CM) determines the policy of the State in the field of education and employment.

The **Ministry of Education and Science** (MES) guides, coordinates and controls the accomplishment of the state policy in the field of vocational education and training. The Ministry regulates and methodically guides the continuing vocational training that is being accomplished through a system of vocational schools, vocational secondary schools, art schools, vocational colleges and the higher schools. The Minister of Education and Science confirms the State Educational Requirements for acquisition of qualifications by professions, approves the List of Professions for vocational education and training, provides conditions for implementation of the

State Educational Requirements to the system of vocational education and training, approves programmes for qualification in the Vocational Education and Training System.

The **Ministry of Labour and Social Policy (MLSP)** develops, coordinates and implements the state policy in the field of the professional qualification of the labour force (employed and unemployed persons). The Ministry is responsible for preparation of the annual National Operation Plan for Employment, for determination of the needs of vocational training by analysis of the trends in the labour market and for the organization of the professional consultation. The Ministry participates in the updating of the National Classifier of Professions.

The **Employment Agency** under the administration of the Minister of Labour and Social Policy implements the state policy for stimulation of the employment, for the defense of labour market, the professional information and consultation, vocational and motivating training of unemployed and employed persons as well as the intermediate services relating employment.

The **National Agency for Vocational Education and Training (NAVET)** is specialized body of the Council of Ministers, created (1999) by the Vocational Education and Training Act, in order to license activities in the field of the vocational education and training and coordinate the institutions related to the vocational orientation, training and education. The Agency elaborates the State Educational Requirements to the system of the vocational education and training as well as the List of Professions for vocational education and training. The National Agency for Vocational Education and Training regulates the vocational training carried out in the licensed centers for vocational training.

The **Ministry of Culture (MC)** implements the state policy in the Art Schools, participates in the development, coordination and updating of the State Educational Requirements for acquisition of qualification by professions; participates in the development, coordination and updating of the List of Professions for vocational education and training.

The Ministry of Health (MH) participates in the coordination of the List of Professions for vocational education and training, determines the chronic diseases and physical injuries that are counter-indicative for vocational education and training for professions given in this list.

Branch Ministries participate in the development, coordination and updating of the State Educational Requirements for acquisition of qualification for professions; participate in the development, coordination and updating of the List of Professions for vocational education and training; participate in the coordination of the State Plan for admission in the schools they are financing; allocate the approved by the budget financial means for vocational education and vocational training and control their usage; name their representatives in the board of managers and the expert commissions under professional lines in the NAVET.

The representative organizations of employers and the organizations of workers and employees on the national level participate in the development, coordination and updating of the State Educational Requirements for acquisition of qualification by professions; participate in the development, coordination and updating of the List of Professions for vocational education and training; name their representatives in the board of managers and the expert commissions under the professional lines in the NAVET; participate in the organization and carrying out the examinations for acquisition of vocational qualification and suggest their representatives for the examination commissions.

The National Council for Promotion of Employment at the Minister of Labour and Social Policy is a permanently operating body for cooperation and consultation in elaborating employment policy.

The National Consultative Council for Vocational Qualification of the Labour Force carries out activities on coordination of the national policy and strategies for vocational training of the labour force, for coordination on national level between the social partners on the life-long learning, for coordination of the needs for vocational training.

On the regional level:

The Directorates “Regional Employment Office”, within the complex of activities for encouraging the employment, organize the realization of the state policy for acquisition of

vocational qualification, suggest measures and training projects, coordinate and support the activities of the local Employment Offices, including services for vocational consulting and orientation within the region.

The Regional Educational Inspectorates work out programmes and strategies for development, functioning and elaboration of educational structures; carry out vocational education and training within the territory of the region.

The permanent and temporary Employment Commissions at the Regional Councils for Regional Development determine, organize and control the implementation of the state policy for encouraging the employment and the training for acquisition of vocational qualification on a regional level.

The regional administration participates in the implementation of the state policy for employment and acquisition of vocational qualification on a regional level.

On the local level:

The Municipalities participate in the policy development in the field of the vocational education and training within their territories regarding the need of specialists and workers; the professional orientation of students, unemployed and other persons; the development of the material-technical bases of schools, Vocational Training Centers and Centers for information and professional orientation through financial means from the Municipality's budget.

The Directorates "Employment Office", within the complex of their inherent mediation activities for finding jobs, provide professional information, consultancy and orientation for submission in the most appropriate programme, employment and training; they organize vocational and motivating training of employed and unemployed persons.

The Councils for Cooperation at the Directorates "Employment Office" of the Employment Agency monitor the implementation of the programmes and measures included in the National Employment Action Plan; control the adherence to the regulations for selection of the respective programmes and measures.

4. Institutions for Continuing Vocational Training

Institutions for formal education and training and non-formal training carry out the continuing vocational training in the country.

Main institutions for continuing vocational training in the field of the formal education and training, according to the VETA, are the vocational schools, the vocational secondary schools, the vocational colleges and Centers for Vocational Training (CVT).

In 2003 the network of vocational institutions in the country included 470 schools, secondary schools and colleges, and among them 421 schools are of the State, 12 – of the Municipalities and 37 are private. In 179 vocational schools, secondary schools and colleges has been carried out continuing professional training.

The National Agency for Vocational Education and Training licenses the Centers for Vocational Training and is monitoring their activities. All Centers licensed after year 2002 offer vocational training for acquisition of first, second and third level of vocational qualification. At this stage 146 licensed Centers and 169 Branches are operating.

The main difficulties, which the institutions for continuing vocational training in the formal system are facing, are related to the shortage of funds necessary to update the material-technical base; lack of modern educational and reference literature; insufficient methodical background of the teachers and lecturers for work with adults; shortage of funds for raising the qualification of the teachers, especially in real productive conditions; insufficiently effective dialogue with the employers and their low interest in participation in the process of continuing vocational training. The schools, which are carrying out continuing vocational training, have additional difficulties due to lack of mechanisms for decentralizing financial administration of the revenues from this activity.

The vocational schools, vocational secondary schools and colleges, as well as the licensed Centers for Vocational Training, certify the completed vocational training by documents complying with the State Educational Requirement for documents in the system of the public education.

The system of the higher education carries out continuing vocational training through specialized units at the higher schools. All higher schools in the country (a total of 51) have units for post-graduate qualification and units for training of persons aged above 16 in professions and specialties.

The enterprises carry out non-formal continuing vocational training of the own employees (28%). The training is in the form of courses for vocational qualification, on-the-job training, participation in seminars, conferences, etc.

According to the People's Health Act, the employers can perform vocational training of unemployed persons also, but under certain conditions.

Non-formal continuing vocational training offer also the Community Centers; such cases are however rare despite the fact that they have potential for such training. Those traditional Bulgarian cultural-educational associations can organize activities for extending the knowledge of the people and their adherence to the achievements of the science, art and culture. In the smaller towns and villages they are the only institutions providing access to a library, Internet and information. That's why, they have to be supported in order to contribute the development of the continuing vocational training.

As a whole, the challenges before the system of the continuing vocational training are related to: improving the mechanisms for information openness and feedback; improving the quality of training and approaching it to characteristics which secure access to the European labour market; creating mechanisms for motivation both the users of qualification services and the organizations that invest in the continuing vocational training; uniting the efforts of all social partners, the bodies of the local government and the non-governmental organizations that have attitude to the development of human resources and the economic progress of the country.

II. STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE

The goal of the development and improving of the continuing vocational training is:

Creation and perfection of conditions for acquisition, expansion and development of the vocational qualification of the labour force with a view to improve its suitability for employment, professional career and individual development.

In connection with the realization of the strategic goal and with a view of the prospects for development during the period 2005-2010, the following basic priorities are determined:

- 1. Improvement of the conditions for access to continuing vocational training.**
- 2. Achievement of efficiency in the interaction between institutions involved in the continuing vocational training.**
- 3. Assurance the high quality of the continuing vocational training.**
- 4. Increasing the investments in the continuing vocational training.**
- 5. Scientific assurance of the continuing vocational training.**

III. ACTIVITIES FOR REALIZATION OF THE STRATEGIC OBJECTIVES

PRIORITY № 1

Improvement of the conditions for access to the continuing vocational training

A necessary condition for inclusion of each person in the continuing vocational training is assuring of equal access opportunities, which do not depend on sex, age, place of residence, ethnic belonging, social and material status. For this reason, the forthcoming actions, aimed at improving the access to the continuing vocational training, should be organized in a system providing to people free access to various levels, forms and methods for acquisition of knowledge and development of skills. The basic principles of this system are: openness, diversity, wide scope, comparativeness, measurability of the results, transparency, and mutual acknowledgment of the qualifications.

For development of the conditions for access to the continuing vocational training it is necessary to:

- o Monitoring and analyzing the trends related to participation of people aged above 16 years in continuing vocational training;
- o Creation of an informative system for demand and supply of continuing vocational training;
- o Improving the legal framework in respect of the access to continuing vocational training;
- o Activating the social environment for life-long learning;
- o Development and implementation of a programme related to motivation for inclusion in continuing vocational training, with a special stress on groups that are disadvantaged in the labour market;
- o Development of methods and conditions for open training, including organization of distance-training through the existing network as well as carrying out e-learning.

	Activity	Responsible institutions⁴	Time limit for	Sources of financing
1.	Analysis of the present situation of the continuing vocational training in the country.	MES, MLSP, NAVET NSI	2005	PHARE Republican Budget
2.	Improving of the legal framework that regulates the possibilities for continuing vocational training.	MES MLSP MF, ME Social partners	2005-2006	Financing not required
3.	Creation of a national information system for the demand and supply of vocational training.	MLSP MES and other Ministries, NAVET Social partners	2005 -2006	PHARE Republican Budget
4.	Development and implementation of a programme motivating inclusion in continuing vocational training.	Employment Agency NIE, NAVET, social partners, organizations of regional and local governments.	2005-2006	Republican Budget
5.	Intensifying the information campaigns for popularization of the continuing vocational training, guidance and counseling	MLSP MES NAVET	2005-2007	Republican Budget
6.	Creation of possibilities for distant-training and e-learning through the existing network of	MES NAVET, regional and local interested	2005-2010	Republican Budget

⁴ In the first line is the leading institution.

	local computer clubs.	institutions and organizations.		
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PRIORITY № 2

Achievement of efficiency in the interaction and coordination of the institutions involved in the continuing vocational training

The strategic significance of the continuing vocational training for improving the competitiveness of the enterprises and the professional growth and adaptability of the labour force, presumes undertaking of mutual responsibilities by the institutions at national, regional and local levels (Ministries; organizations of employers, workers and employees; regional and local governments). In order to achieve maximal flexibility of the relationships between the continuing vocational training and the needs of the labour market it is necessary to develop effective cooperation and interaction at all levels – national, regional and local.

The realization of this priority requires accomplishment of the following activities:

- o Creation of administrative capacity for coordinating the cooperation between the institutions and social partners on policies in the field of the continuing vocational training;
- o Elaboration of the legal framework for determination the responsibilities of the institutions involved in continuing vocational training;
- o Expanding the scope of the collective negotiation for the training with a view to improve the adaptability of the enterprises and their labour force to the labour market;
- o Creation of a network for open dialogue between institutions involved in the continuing vocational training on national, regional and local levels;
- o Expanding at regional and local levels the services in the field of the continuing vocational training, providing an accessible for the specific target groups' form.

	Activity	Responsible institutions	Time limit for execution	Sources of financing
1.	Creation of administrative capacity for coordination of the inter-institutional cooperation in the field of continuing training.	MLSP MES NAVET	2005	Republican Budget
2.	Elaboration of the normative order considering the responsibilities of the institutions involved in the continuing vocational training.	MLSP Ministries Social partners	2005-2006	Financing not required
3.	Development measures for improvement the frame of the collective negotiation for the continuing vocational training of the labour force.	MLSP Ministries Social partners	2005-2007	Republican Budget
4.	Activating the participation of the society in the dialogue on the continuing vocational training at regional and local levels.	Institutions and organizations on regional and local levels.	2005-2007	Republican Budget
5.	Creation on a local level of Coordinating Councils for continuing vocational training under a voluntary principle.	Employment Agency Labour Offices Regional Education Inspectorate, Institutions and organizations on local level, social partners.	2005-2006	Republican Budget

6.	Popularization of programmes for continuing vocational training.	MLSP Ministries Social partners Institutions and organizations on regional and local levels.	2005-2010	Republican Budget
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PRIORITY № 3

Assurance the high quality of the continuing vocational training.

The high quality is paramount necessity for the continuing vocational training in order to secure comparability with the European practices by 2010. The high quality of the training reflects directly upon the suitability for employment of the labour force, upon the productivity and competitive power of both the enterprises and labour force to reduce the unemployment and overcome the social isolation. This priority is bound with the forthcoming actions aiming at increasing the employment, laid down in the Employment Strategy for 2004-2010.

For this goal it is envisaged:

- o Improving the qualification of the teaching staff in the field of continuing vocational training;
- o Improving the qualification of the suppliers of continuing vocational training;
- o Elaborating a package of general principles for validation of the non-formal training or the self-dependent studying, for securing compatibility with those of the countries of the European Union;
- o Introducing the European tools for acknowledgment and evaluation of qualifications;
- o Achieving high studying culture through informing, consulting and orientation;
- o Updating the material-technical educational base.

#	Activity	Responsible institutions	Time limit for execution	Sources of financing
1.	Preparation and execution of programmes for improvement the qualification of the teaching staff in the field of continuing vocational training.	MES Institutions engaged in qualification of the teaching staff MLSP, nationally represented organizations of employers.	2005-2008	PHARE Republican Budget
2.	Carrying out programmes for training of managers of the institutions – suppliers of continuing vocational training for strategic planning, for determination of the needs of training, marketing of the qualification services, etc.	MLSP MES NAVET ME Social partners	2005-2008	Republican Budget
3.	Motivating the higher schools to include in the curriculum of the pedagogical specialties training in andragogics.	MES Higher schools	2005-2006	Financing not required.
4.	Updating the material base in order to carry out continuing vocational training.	Responsible institutions on national, regional and local levels.	2005-2010	PHARE European Social Fund, Republican Budget, private capital, sponsors, donors.
5.	Development and implementation of a system for validation of the qualification acquired through non-formal training or self-dependent studies.	MES MLSP Social partners	2005-2007	Republican Budget

6.	Building a system and introduction of European instruments for acknowledgement and assessment of qualifications.	MES MLSP NAVET	2005-2008	Republican Budget
7.	Training of employers in disbursement of resources from the target funds for vocational training of the staff.	MLSP Branch Chambers	2005-2007	Republican Budget European Social Fund

PRIORITY № 4**Increasing the investments in the continuing vocational training**

The investments in the human capital in Bulgaria during the past years mark contradicting trends. Despite that a great part of the employers and individuals are aware about the importance of this factor, the share of the vocational training carried out is still insufficient. It is necessary to overcome the negative influence of the population's low income, the economic instability and the lack of understanding by some of the employers.

In this context essential is the following:

- o Achieving of awareness by the staff about the provided by the employers continuing vocational training; spreading good practices;
- o Introducing new measures and tax stimuli for encouraging the employers to raise the qualification of their workers and employees;
- o Introducing effective measures for encouraging unemployed to participate in continuing vocational training, accounting for the specificity of regions with structural unemployment, rural regions and risk groups;
- o Raising the managerial culture of the employers in respect of elaboration of short-term, middle-term and long-term plans for development of the human resources in the small and medium-sized enterprises.
- o Introducing new measures and encouragements to stimulate the individual person to participate in continuing vocational training.

#	Activity	Responsible institutions	Time limit for execution	Sources of financing
1.	Extension of the measures for encouragement the initiatives for continuing vocational training of unemployed, conformed to the specific needs of the regions and the target groups. Involving the Municipalities in planning of the resource support of the continuing vocational training in their territory.	MLSP MF, ME Regional Educational Inspectorate Municipal administrations and other institutions involved in the continuing vocational training.	2005-2010	Republican Budget European Social Fund
2.	Expansion and optimization of the measures for stimulation employers to raise the qualification of their workers and employees.	MLSP MF, ME and organizations of employers, other institutions involved in the continuing vocational training.	2005-2010	Republican Budget European Social Fund
3.	Creation and realization of projects for training of employers in elaboration of human resources at the small and medium-sized enterprises.	MLSP ME Organizations of employers	2005-2007	Republican Budget
4.	Expansion of the measures for stimulation of the individual person to participate in continuing vocational training.	MLSP MF, ME Organizations of workers and employees, other institutions involved in the continuing vocational training.	2005-2010	Republican Budget
5.	Amendment of the valid financial	MES	2005	Republican

	procedures in order to transform the received in the state schools own income into a stimulus for securing the activities on continuing vocational training.	MF		Budget
6.	Introduction of measures in the regional development plans related to development of the human resource through continuing vocational training.	MRDPW Regional and local government.	2005-2010	Republican Budget

PRIORITY № 5**Scientific assurance of the continuing vocational training**

The existing of an effective system for continuing vocational training presumes existence of a methodology, didactic approaches, analyses and research. The scientific research capacity of the higher schools for analysis and support of the continuing vocational training in the country and for research studies that help the development of policies in the field of continuing vocational training is not adequately used. In the different administrations, including those on the national level, research activity in the field of development of human resources is almost missing. This disturbs the process of building decisions in the course of time and reflects unfavourably on their quality.

For execution of this priority is envisaged:

- o Methodological support of the pedagogical staff in carrying out continuing vocational training of persons older than 16 years;
- o Information securing of the research activity;
- o Collecting, popularizing and implementing of good practices in the field of continuing vocational training.

#	Activity	Responsible institutions	Time limit for execution	Sources for financing
1.	Development of the scientific research capacity and institutional building.	MES MLSP, ME, MF Organizations of employers	2005-2007	Republican Budget
2.	Development and implementation of a methodology for training of adults.	MES, MLSP NAVET, NIE	2005-2007	PHARE, Republican Budget
3.	Spreading the results of the research activity in the field of continuing vocational training.	MLSP MES, NAVET NIE, Institutions and organizations on national level.	2007-2010	Republican Budget
4.	Study, popularization and implementation of good practices in the field of continuing vocational training.	MLSP MES, NAVET NIE	2005-2010	Republican Budget

IV. FINANCIAL SECURITY OF THE CONTINUING VOCATIONAL TRAINING

Investing in the quality of the human resources is a component of the general social policy of Republic of Bulgaria⁵.

The analysis of the existing trends in the development of the continuing vocational training and the challenges of the accession to the European Union impose the conclusion that it is necessary to invest sensibly more in the training. Accomplishment of the objectives and the national priorities laid down in the Strategy requires significant financial resources.

As a whole, an increase in the share of the public expenses for education is expected, including vocational training (for 2002 it is 4.6% of the GDP; according to preliminary data for 2003, the share is 4.9% of the GDP)⁶.

It is necessary to increase considerably the funds that the employers invest in updating and raising the vocational qualification of the employed in the enterprises labour force.

The used approach for **programme orientation** of funds from the Republican Budget should be applied on a common basis. This will allow maximally effective realization of the financial means in achievement of the goals of the Strategy through the responsible institutions – MLSP, MES, MF, ME, MRDPW, MYS and other agencies and administrations. All of them will work for fulfillment of the basic priorities of the Strategy, in conformity with the time frame.

The influx of funds from **international aid** will continue to represent a significant contribution to securing of means for vocational training to be used by various institutions and target groups.

On this ground, for the period 2005-2010 is envisaged use of the following sources for financing the continuing vocational training:

- o Funds from the Republican Budget, allocated to responsible institutions, regional and municipal administrations;
- o The PHARE programme – in the Section “Social and Economic Cohesion”;
- o Structural funds of the European Union (after 2007);
- o International resources;
- o Funds of employers, including application of schemes for cooperation between small and medium-sized enterprises, as well as uniting financial resources for carrying out training for professional qualification;
- o Own revenues of suppliers of professional training;
- o Personal funds for development of the individual labour force;
- o Other funds – of the Municipalities, local legal persons, non-governmental organizations, etc.
- o Sponsorships, donations etc.

The effective utilization of the above possibilities for financing the continuing vocational training presumes a high degree of coordination in this activity, in compliance with the priorities of the continuing vocational training on various levels.

⁵ Governmental programme, National Plan for Economic Development (2000-2006), National Plan of Action on the Employment (2002, 2003, 2004), Joint Report for Assessment of the Priorities in the Employment Policy of Republic of Bulgaria and Report for the Progress in 2003, Strategy for Employment for 2004-2010 and others.

⁶ According to data of the National Statistics Institute.

V. EXPECTED RESULTS

In the time of social-economic alterations in the society, it is necessary that the suppliers of continuing vocational training direct their activities toward the needs of the labour market. Closer cooperation between all institutions having attitude towards the continuing vocational training will raise the correspondence of the training courses with the present and future needs of the labour market.

The implementation of the strategy should lead to:

- o Creation of active informative system for the demand and supply of continuing vocational training;
- o Improvement of the information and motivation of people for participation in the continuing vocational training;
- o Increase in the number of participants in the continuing vocational training;
- o Improvement of the interaction and coordination between institutions and organizations responsible for the continuing vocational training on national, regional and local levels;
- o Improvement of the correspondence between demand and supply of vocational qualifications;
- o Strengthening the capacity of suppliers of professional training in respect of their marketing activity and the quality of the offered continuing vocational training;
- o Increasing the number of offered courses for continuing vocational training as a part of the labour market's active measures for achievement of sustained employment.
- o Improvement of the access to e-learning by building of infrastructures as a flexible training form and stimulus for development of the continuing vocational training;
- o Reduction of the regional discrepancies related to the employment and labour market.
- o Growth of the media interest and activity of the public dialogue on the problems of the continuing vocational training.

VI. MONITORING THE ACTIVITIES ON IMPLEMENTATION OF THE STRATEGY

The monitoring of the activities on implementation of the Strategy is meant to secure their timely and quality fulfillment.

The variety of the activities requires that each one is subjected to special monitoring. For this purpose it is necessary to concretize in respective tasks the fulfillment of each activity. Those tasks should allow assessment and control of the progress in the implementation of the Strategy in conformity with the specificity of the different parameters. The subject of the monitoring is determined by the circle of the indicated institutions, which are responsible for the implementation of the Strategy.

The implementation of the Strategy as a whole, tables the necessity of carrying out also a general monitoring. Its main goal is to secure synchronization and mutual assistance at the realization of planned activities and priorities. It is envisaged that this monitoring will be accomplished as a function of the created administrative capacity for coordination of the inter-institutional cooperation in the field of the policies for continuing vocational training, laid down as activity № 1 in priority № 2.

GLOSSARY OF THE MAIN TERMS

Continuing vocational training – training of people older than 16 years to acquire, expand and increase their professional qualification with the aim to improve their employment suitability, support their professional career and individual development.

Formal training – Training that is carried out within the frame of the institutions for vocational training, identified in art. 18 of the VETA, and is characterized by obtaining of a nationally acknowledged document for certification of the acquired qualification.

Non-formal training – Training that is carried out within the frames of each organized activity outside the formal system.

Self-dependent studying – A process of studying (and self-education) during the entire life, by means of which are acquired knowledge and skills, adjustments, intellectual values of the everyday experience, through educational influence and sources of the surrounding social and material environment, including libraries and mass media.

Life-long learning – a process of learning and acquiring of knowledge by means of formal and non-formal training and studying, as well as through self-dependent studying, during the entire vital activity of the person.

The life-long learning is considered by the society to be one of the most important factors for development and elaboration of the professional realization and for encouraging active participation of the people in the economic life. It is a necessary prerequisite for free movement of the labour force and a leading principle for further development of the system of education and training in Bulgaria.

Glossary of some acronyms used in the text for sake of brevity:

CA	Crafts Act
CM	Council of Ministers
CVT	Centre for Vocational Training
EA	Employment Agency
EPA	Employment Promotion Act
ESF	European Social Fund
GDP	Gross Domestic Product
HEA	Higher Education Act
PCCA	People's Community Centers Act
PEA	Public Education Act
PHA	People's Health Act
REI	Regional Educational Inspectorate
VET	Vocational Education and Training
VETA	Vocational Education and Training Act
LC	Labour Code
MC	Ministry of Culture
ME	Ministry of Economy
MES	Ministry of Education and Science
MF	Ministry of Finance
MH	Ministry of Health
MLSP	Ministry of Labour and Social Policy
MRDPW	Ministry of Regional Development and Public Works
MYS	Ministry of Youth and Sport
NAVET	National Agency for Vocational Education and Training
NIE	National Institute of Education
NSI	National Statistical Institute

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